

Writing

Personal essay

The lessons we take from obstacles we encounter can be fundamental to later success. Recount a time when you faced a challenge, setback, or failure. How did it affect you, and what did you learn from the experience?

It was half past three when I awoke and crept downstairs to my fish tank. Five of my goldfish were sleeping, but I had six fish. Alarmed, I rubbed my eyes. Had I missed one? One, two, three, four, five, where had the last one gone?

An hour of searching later, I found my oldest goldfish, Buddy, whom I had spent four years with, behind the driftwood, barely alive, too far gone to be saved. I could only watch as he faded away.

Four years ago, when I received this fish tank, I cherished it. It was the first time I felt a sense of purpose in life after losing my beloved beagle, Apple. Despite how much I loved caring for the fish, the tank fell into disrepair. It was just one more thing I needed to do on top of school, extracurriculars, and other responsibilities. I kept putting off cleaning it because the fish looked fine, and for two years, I let it reach the brink before doing a water change.

As I sat in my basement, feeling helpless, I thought about how small acts of neglect can turn into a catastrophe over time. That's when I remembered something my swim coach said after a tough practice. "Progress doesn't come naturally or from talent. It comes from consistency, hard work and genuine care." His words, echoing as I stood by my fish tank, etched themselves into my brain and reframed everything.

I realized that rather than feeling guilt over neglecting my fish tank, I could focus on facing the responsibility I had and choosing to care even when it's difficult or inconvenient.

I was forced to confront the truth about why I became disinterested in the first place. I

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After Buddy died, I stopped avoiding difficult emotions and began putting in time and effort into both myself and the things I cared about, even when it wasn't easy. I began to work with a therapist, sitting with my thoughts every night before bed, and journaling. Reconnecting with myself allowed me to shift my focus to reconnecting with others. As I connected with others, my interests and passions gained more depth.

I realized that I actually cared deeply about many issues and that my enthusiasm could bring people together to brainstorm, organize, and plan solutions that would impact others. This allowed me to lead projects like EmpowerAIM and KidstoKids, which taught me how small, consistent actions and care can have an effect far beyond myself.

These projects allowed me to mentor youth on something I wish I had known sooner: how to be in touch with their emotions, to reconnect and trust themselves. I've seen how the fear of failure can just as easily hold others back from reaching their capabilities.

Being in touch with my emotions also allowed me to better resonate with others and see what they're going through. One student, at my English program at KidstoKids, Surui, was too afraid of being wrong to speak up. I saw that his fear was a reflection of the fear I had overcome. Slowly, through encouragement, I helped him gain confidence. Months later, as we wrapped up the program, Surui stayed back and said, "Jerry, thanks for believing in me." Caring had changed us both. What began as a promise to myself grew into a lifelong commitment to care for myself and others.

Additional information

Additional Circumstances:

On October 22nd, I suffered a concussion, resulting in severe pain, memory and speech issues, vision impairment, and a sensitivity to screens and light. I am expected to make a full recovery, but this has impacted my ability to write application essays.

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Additional Honors:

Youth Global Creative Challenge by UN and Netflix Global Finalist (2025)

Secured Top 13 out of 2280 apps from 89 countries (Top 0.5%). The Challenge is co-organized by the UN and Netflix as a multimedia business case competition and created a 10-minute video integrating empowerAIM's educational components along with an official interview conducted in New York at UNHQ by the UN Youth Office. The video focused on developing a viable path for the organization's mission to be scalable across global youth communities, based on feedback received at UN STI Forum 2025.

Links:

EmpowerAIM Website: <https://empoweraim.wixsite.com/empoweraim>

EmpowerAIM UNESCO Presentation: <https://www.learning-planet.org/event/empoweraim-presents-enabling-an-empowered-and-ethical-ai-evolution/>

EmpowerAIM Global Finalist at Youth Global Creative Challenge 2025:
<https://www.youthstudios.org/challenge>

EmpowerAIM Youtube Channel Feature Video: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Qa7qLCWqa70>

EmpowerAIM on FutureofTechnology Platform: <https://www.futureoftechnology.org/ggw?pgid=Impltrpg-97711f66-8d0a-4abd-b908-893feaf3ae6f>

Personal Profile on FutureofTechnology: <https://www.futureoftechnology.org/jerry-huang>

KidstoKids Website: <http://kidstokids.ca/>

KidstoKids YouTube Channel: <https://www.youtube.com/@KidstoKidsNPO>

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Details

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